Combat rule – Ambush · SRD 5.2.1

An **ambush** is a fight where one side prepares in hiding before the other notices. The **Surprise** rule gives the effect (Disadvantage on initiative); this sheet explains **how to set up an ambush** and resolve it with **Hide** and **Search**.

🎲 Quick summary:

1. Ambushers hide: **Stealth DC 15**.
2. Hidden = **Invisible**: **Advantage** on initiative.
3. Those who notice nothing: **Disadvantage** on initiative.
4. The first hidden attack has **advantage**.

⚠ Change from 2014

SRD 2024 no longer makes a surprised creature lose its turn: it only has Disadvantage on initiative.

⚠ Flaw in the rule and fixes Table rule

The SRD doesn't say how to decide who notices the ambush. Fix: compare the victims' **passive Perception** with the ambushers' Stealth result.

💡 Narrative option: Table rule

The DM can give a subtle clue before the attack (birds taking flight, sudden silence).

Step 1 – Prepare:

Ambushers take cover, out of the targets' sight (see Hiding in Combat).

Step 2 – Test:

Each ambusher makes a **Dexterity (Stealth) DC 15** check.

Step 3 – Notice:

A victim whose **passive Perception** is below the result doesn't notice the threat.

Step 4 – Initiative:

Hidden creatures have **Advantage** on initiative (Invisible); victims who noticed nothing have **Disadvantage**.

Step 5 – Attack:

An attack from hiding has **Advantage**; the attacker is then revealed.

Example: three bandits hide behind rocks (Stealth 14, 16, 18). The paladin has passive Perception 15: he notices the first two, not the third.

When	Ambushers	Victims
Setup	Hide (Stealth DC 15)	Passive Perception
Initiative	Advantage (Invisible)	Disadvantage if nothing noticed
First turn	Attack with Advantage	React normally
After attacking	Revealed	Can strike back
Afterwards	Ordinary combat	Ordinary combat

⚠ Common questions:

Who is surprised?

Those who don't notice the threat.

Do I lose my turn?

No, only Disadvantage on initiative.

Can I ambush in daylight?

Yes, with suitable cover.

Does it work on a group?

Yes, creature by creature.

If one ambusher is seen?

The others stay hidden.

Is a roll always needed?

No, if the DM finds the threat obvious.

⚠ Debate points and table options: Table rule

Passive or active

Do victims roll? **Option**: passive only.

Lookout

Does an alert lookout cancel surprise? **Option**: yes for the whole group.

Initiative advantage

Do hidden creatures always get it? **Option**: yes, Invisible state.

Player ambush

Do PCs who plan everything get a bonus? **Option**: +2 to Stealth.

⚠ Rule clarifications (answers found on the web, reworded):

Surprise

See the Surprise sheet for the exact effect.

Hiding

The hiding conditions are in the dedicated sheet.

Search

An action to actively look for a hidden enemy.

These points remain open to discussion: your feedback is welcome to refine this sheet.

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